negotiations with EaEU are driven by the desire to carve out a political and economic space for itself in Central Asia, which is sandwiched between Russia and China. It is a strategically important region for India, as it borders Iran, Afghanistan, and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. The tacit arrangement within SCO has hitherto been that Russia would be the net security provider, while the dominant economic influence would be that of China. With the rapid expansion of Chinese investments in the BRI, China may upset this delicate balance by asserting its political and security interests. It is in India's interest to closely monitor (and influence, where possible) the Russia–China dynamics in Central Asia. The Central Asian countries have signalled that they would welcome India breaking into this Russia–China duopoly.

India's direct overland route to Central Asia is blocked by political and security issues in Pakistan and Afghanistan. An alternative route, which has been sporadically under negotiation between India, Russia, and Iran since 2002, is the International North–South Transport Corridor (INSTC), a multimodal trade corridor from India's west coast to Iran and onwards to Central Asia (with spurs to Afghanistan and Russia and onward connection to Europe). The project gathered steam again after the nuclear deal of 2016 led to the lifting of UN sanctions against Iran. India has developed a container terminal in Iran's Chabahar port and is committed to establishing a rail link northward from Chabahar to Zahedan, which would be a bridgehead to Central Asia. The route has other economic and strategic advantages. It gives Central Asia its shortest access to the sea. Chabahar is Uzbekistan's nearest seaport and Turkmenistan's shortest link to the Indian Ocean. INSTC offers not only India but all of South, Southeast, and East Asia a cost-effective trade route to Central Asia, Russia, and Europe, avoiding both China and the lengthy sea route. The Chinese BRI involves creation of transport corridors,